

The terrified beast dives into the acid, hoping for some respite against the dangerous adventurers that have brought it to death's door. As he does so, Wang Lei finds a wellspring of infernal energy within himself. The teddy bear on his belt rumbles as black smoke erupts from all around him. Just as the False Hydra breaks the surface of the lake, the *Hellish Rebuke* spell detonates, disintegrating the Hydra. The gray, matted flesh of the Hydra dissolves in the acid, turning back to translucent slime.

Submerged in the acid, both Thaisha and Wang Lei feels its blistering touch once more. The burning sensation knocks both of them out, bringing them into unconsciousness.

The Party sees the half-orc resurface. Slinging over to the column, Vilde fires her web again pulling out the half-orc. Wang Lei, trapped by the very steel meant to protect him, sinks deeper into the boiling green deep.

An Upset Patron

Wang Lei, you are falling. You feel the cold metal of your armour hugging you and then pulling you slowly deeper and deeper into the dark abyss. Your vision blacks out as you feel the burning acid pour into your lungs.

As the paladin sinks out of reach of his allies, he slips into unconsciousness. He wonders if this is truly his end, and feels regret at his uncompleted pursuits.

As you slip into unconsciousness, you find yourself back in the crypts under the Church of Caishenye. In front of you, lying silently on a raised altar, is Sister Clara. Resting over her eyes are two gold ingots, placed there in line with the customs of your religion, to provide some form of comfort as the dead make their way into the afterlife.

"Another one dead," The Child taunts. "With you as my champion, it won't be long before I join her."

Materialising in a cloud of black smoke, is the Child. The first thing you notice, Wang Lei, is that he looks much bigger now. His eyes are still black, infinite voids, but the first time you met him you would've guessed that maybe he was three or four? Now, he looks like he's thirteen or fourteen.

"Why did you go fight the False Hydra?" He asks, in a soft voice on the verge of tears. "You *knew* Nanny Po'po was attacking the camp. Why didn't you grab her?"

The Child appears, furious that Wang Lei has chosen to fight the False Hydra instead of staying up on the surface to defend Camp Vengeance and capture Nanny Po'po. Wang Lei explains that the Hydra was a much bigger threat, and had to be dealth with. The Child screams and yells, attacking Wang Lei.

"You're supposed to serve ME!" The Child screams. "Not run around doing stupid shit! I've been watching you know. I watch you stand aside and let that bastard elf and the megalomaniac of a sorcerer bring you wherever they want! I thought you were a leader! I thought you were going to save me! If you aren't going to help me, if you are going to go back on our deal, then fine! So be it! I can make your life *very* miserable, you know."

He glares back at you, tears swimming in his eyes.

Wang Lei tries to explain that "there's so much to do," and that he has to make his decisions carefully. He breaks down, explaining that "it is difficult to juggle everything."

The Child screams as you see the vision dissipates. Your eyes snap open. You feel yourself start to ascend, and as you kick with all your might to the surface, you realize that your armour has fallen away from you, dismantled by the Child's magic.

You break the surface of the acid just as Vilde's web hits you, pulling you up into the air.

A Druid of the Emerald Circle

The Emerald Circle is a powerful organisation of druids and other nature worshipers based out of the Verdant Reach. They seek to preserve the order of nature and strive to defeat any forces that seek to harm nature. Having been a defender of nature, Thaisha was initially antagonistic against Raphael, Salazar, and Vilde for their involvement in the construction of the mines in the Russett Jungle. She is, however, on great terms with Hazel and Wang Lei, seeing them as fellow conservationists. This has, of course, changed over time, given that the Party has worked together in multiple life-and-death situations. After the Party were shown to their tents yesterday, she was abducted while washing her face by the basin.

Salazar and Hazel both rush over to heal the injured. As Thaisha comes to, she heads over and to one of the corpses. The Party realizes that this is Fearne; a member of Thaisha's order in the Circle of the Land that had gone missing in Kroonstad whilst on a pilgrimage to visit her goddess's holy site Tamoachan.

As the Party beings investigating the dead bodies littered in the cave, Wang Lei heads off to a quiet corner of the cave to meditate.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check

On a successful **DC 15** check, the Players find the *Gauntlets of Eldritch Ferocity*, a *Staff of Storms*, a *Ring of Roaring Fire*, a *Rod of Absorption*, 9 empty spell glyphs, and spare parts to assemble for a Dungeoneer's Backpack and a Breastplate.

As all of you begin to inspect the bodies, Salazar, you find a handsome dwarf with a brown leather eye-patch. You recognize this person: lying dead on the ground is the Archmage Dead-Eye Demodus, a powerful illusory wizard who was your former superior in the Ring of Gold.

Intelligence (History) Check

On a successful **DC 15** check, Salazar recalls that he departed as part of the 22nd Expedition, almost three weeks prior to himself. On a successful **DC 20** check, Salazar ascertains that he was the leader of the Expedition.





The 22nd Expedition

A group of adventurers recruited by the *Eyes of the Emperor* to find and destroy the Devourer. They met their untimely end in the cave, taking on the legendary False Hydra.

- **Dead-Eye Demodus**, the Archmage of Illusion of the Ring of Gold,
- **Fearne,** a Circle of the Land druid,
- **Cregan Khudu**, a Berserker barbarian,
- **Hank Rivers**, a Beast Master ranger,
- **Suvi Wilhand,** a cleric of Guanyinma,
- **A Flash of Green,** a tabaxi swashbuckler rogue,
- **Jaime Lannister the Second**, a fighter and warlock of an unknown dark goddess.

Whilst they failed in their endeavor to slay the Hydra, they learnt that the Graying is likely to accelerate: Those who fall unconscious would soon also contract the Graying, and those with the Graying succumb to their wounds at twice the rate.

Collecting their research, Salazar learns that the deceased Party has deduced that the Devourer is collecting souls to feed and nourish a stillborn godling known as the Atropal. They postulate that the Atropal's hunger is likely to increase as it grows larger, which would lead to the Graying accelerating.

Dead-Eye Demodus was also performing research into killing liches, and in particular, Acererak. He has been in communication with someone called Gemini, who writes back that "While the traditional way of killing a lich is by destroying their phylactery then destroying their physical body, this method would not be possible for Acererak as he has multiple, living phylacteries." They also find research dedicated to finding Relics, including one known as the *Plate of the Dawnmartyr* for its abilities to withstand a Sphere of Annihilation.

Demodus and his Party has also deduced that the Sewn Sisters - what he called the hags nursing the undead baby god - have been rearing monstrosities like the False Hydra and unleashing them to cause as much death as possible, consuming the souls of those who died. They have also marked out that they have been tracking a different monster - the King of Feathers.

Khan comes over to Wang Lei, who is deep in meditation. The tiger purrs and rubs its head against the paladin, casting *Healing Touch*. As Wang Lei comes out of meditation, he casts *Lay on Hands* on himself and drinks 2 *Potions of Healing* before rejoining the group with the bodies.

Thaisha pulls Hazel aside, passing her some parchement from Fearne's research. She shares that Tamoachan was not merely a famed lost shrine dedicated to Saleander, but also a mausoleum dedicated to her first three prophets.

Not a follower of Saleander, she also asks Hazel to help lay Fearne to rest. She confesses that she is unfamiliar with the funereal rites of their religion, and asks how it is typically conducted.

Hazel explains that they merely "borrow their bodies from Saleander, and upon death need to return their bodies as quickly as possible by way of rapid decomposition." The cleric asks Thaisha to help throw her body into the acid, as she utters a quick word of prayer.

> As you are about to leave the cave, Wang Lei you feel your new breastplate on you. It is much lighter, but less familiar. You take one last look down, and see the armour that has, for so long, marked your rank and station sink to the bottom of the acid, dissolving away slowly.

The Siege of Camp Vengeance

Back on the surface, Nanny Po'po, is launching an assault against Camp Vengeance; she is determined to hunt and destroy the False Hydra set loose by the Sewn Sisters.

> As all of you step out of the dark underground cavern, you see that a scene of complete pandemonium. Lightning flashes in the distant night as blinding, relentless sheets of rain turn the camp into a muddy battlefield.



The western wall has collapsed. Panicked, shivering recruits drop their spears and shields as they scramble to form a line to hold back the horde. Princess and Duo are on the opposite side of the ditch, roaring as they try to bring down an ogre. You see Lieutenant Breakbones, not giving orders at all, but focused on throwing injured soldiers on her back and dashing to the field hospital to drop them off to the clearly overwhelmed Sister Cyas. Just out of the corner of your eyes, on the northern wall, you see Ayo and Yandala fighting back skeletons that are starting to crest the palisades. One of them grapples Ayo and tumbles backwards, dropping behind the wall.

What do you all do?

Skill Challenges

A skill challenge is an encounter that allows players to creatively use skills to make progresses and build tension. It takes what is typically a montage scene (e.g. a chase scene) from a movie and translates it into the game.

After rolling Initiative, each player is given a scene or a problem; they then address the problem with a relevant skill check, accumulating successes and failures along the way. They are encouraged to be creative, and pitch whatever relevant skills or features they have (beyond what is given) to help accumulate the relevant number of successes.

Defending Camp Vengeance

Conditions	Remarks
Successes	5
Failures	3
Turn Time	20 mins
Primary Skills	*Athletics*, *Performance*, *Medicine*

The DC for all checks is 15. Strength (Athletics) checks can be used to pull people out of harm's way. Charisma (Performance) checks can be used to rally and marshal troops, while Wisdom (Medicine) checks can be used to triage and help patch up the injured.

On a failure, the western wall is destroyed. On 2 failures, the northern wall is also destroyed and the tents are overrun. On three failures, the southern wall falls and the camp is lost, prompting various NPCs to flee.

Bursting out from the ground, the Party goes to work.

"Help is here!" Raphael's booming voice declares. The soldiers on the northern wall heed the rallying cry, cutting down the cresting undead as the sorcerer and rogue joins them to hold the line.

Wang Lei rides out to battle at the fallen wall, leaping over the ditch with Khan and slashing wildly at the horde. Wukong enlarges his Jingubang, leaping into action as the pair of paladins engage in a whirlwind of violence.

As *Lightning Bolt* ignites a watchtower, Salazar rushes into action. He catches a falling soldier with his *Mage Hand* as Thaisha calls down lightning bolts, incinerating a group of skeletons.

Seeing the overwhelmed Sister Cyas, Hazel bounds towards the Field Hospital. She expertly applies a torniquet on a wounded soldier, stemming the relentless blood pouring out of his arm.

Back at the northern wall, Raphael watches as a Guardsman gets disemboweled in front of him. Blasting back the villianous skeleton, he steps over the injured soldier and puts his head over the open abdomen. Purple tentacles explode into existence, knitting back the wound together.

As first light breaks out over the horizon, you hear a thunderous roar go up against the army as they begin to retreat. You watch the monsters take off into the treeline in various directions, scattering all around you.

You collapse into the mud-soaked ground of the battlefield, overwhelmed with exhaustion but victorious. As the rain begin to subside and the sun peeks its cheery face over the camp, you feel your muscles burn from the terrible night.

Surveying the camp, you see the fallen wall. Sister Cyas rushes to-and-fro, tending to the injured and trying her best to make sure they don't end up with the dead.

In the brief respite as the battle concludes, before the long work of tending and mending to the defenses of the camp, what do you all do?

As the enemy retreats, the Party spreads out to get a better sensing of the environment. They do not find Nanny Po'po, and are surprised to find also that Captain Jarlaxle, Xasha and Florina are all gone.

The Party discusses what to do. Hazel suggests that they continue on their journey, but Vilde insists that they should stay, at least until they finish resting and gathering their strength. Raphael suggest that they could help fortify the place, and take up the Lieutenant's offer to use Camp Vengeance as a forward operating base of sorts. The Party also tries to decide where they should go next, torn between Mezro to learn more about the War of Axe and Vine and Zarula to find the hag.

Queen of Africa

In the midst of your debate, you hear a triumphant trumpet call. Looking around, near the Gatehouse, you see a halfling in half plate armour with bright orange hair and a huge nose clamber up onto a crate and shout:

"Presenting Lyara Porter, First of Her Name, Queen of the New African Republic, Castellan of the Victorian Revolutionary Guard, Duchess of Sempter and Director of the East African Trading Company!"

Entering the Camp, you see a middle-aged human woman with a look of mild disapproval etched into her face. By her side, you see two people dressed in teal robes. On her left is a tiefling, bright pink skin, with ears like goat and two sharp red horns rising from her brows. The man on the right is someone Raphael, Salazar and Vilde recognize. He has glowing face tattoos and a shock of cyan colored hair. This is the Scion of House Luxjaro, one of the noble houses in the Chamber of Lords-Advisory.

Lyara Porter's delegation, comprising of six knights and sixteen guards, arrives. She is accompanied by Benedict Luxjaro and his attendant Charity, who are here on behalf of the Candescent Church. Displeased at the state of the camp, she talks down to Dame Breakbones, dismissing her.



"Now, now," the Castellan sneers. "I must say, even I didn't expect the depth of your incompetence. A fortified camp has four walls, sugar. There are almost none left."

The Castellan notices the 52nd Expedition as she takes in the camp. "And who the devils are all of you?" She asks.

Intelligence (History) Check
On a successful **DC 15** check, Lyara Portyr recognises that Wang Lei as Eddard's son. On a successful **DC 20** check, she also recognizes Vilde's choker on a former assailant.

"You're Eddard's boy," Lyara Porter realizes. "Oh, I've heard great things. Now, this is obviously a shitshow. Niles, I would love to hear your excuses for this," She turns to Wang Lei, taking his arm. "Please, come. Perhaps you can teach this *tusker* over here how to run a proper Camp."

The pair, followed by a glowering Breakbones, enters the Commanders' Tent.

The Scion of House Luxjaro

Benedict Luxjaro, recognizing Raphael, Vilde, and Salazar, comes up to speak with Raphael. Benedict and Raphael had previously spent time together at the Society of the Six, and were part of the same cohort together. Benedict tells Vilde about how Raphael was a menace on the Duelling Greens, and almost went undefeated during his time at the Society - Hinari was the only one that beat him.

As the conversation lulls, Benedict leans in and asks quietly, "I know you're here on behalf of the expedition, ya da ya da, but why are you *really* here in this shitty ass jungle?"

Raphael explains that he is hunting Kaelen, because the noble took something of his. Benedict laughs, and says "well, I'm not sure if you've heard, but House Tychonis has launched a direct assault against Castle Yucatan and successfully destroyed it. The Tychonis now rule Coatlan." Realizing that Kaelen's ancestral home and seat of power is gone, Raphael cannot help but smile a little to himself.

"What about you?" Raphael asks in exchange. "What brings you to Kroonstad?"

"Officially? To spread the good gospel of the Candescent Church," Benedict smiles smugly. "But really, I'm here to kill a god." He goes on to brag that he has convinced Lyara Porter that the Chamber will back her claim of royalty, prompting her to increase efforts to seize lands so as to build and establish settlements. In actuality, he is co-opting the Guard to find and destroy Tamoachan, one of Saleander's holy sites. He explains that by killing her followers and destroying her holy sites, they can permanently destroy Saleander.

Raphael ponders this revelation. He has known House Luxjaro as a family of sorcerers, and is perplexed about their desire to get into the religion business.



Benedict also congratulates Vilde, sharing the latest in in elven news: Khan the Younger has announced his retirement as the Elven Prime Minister, and word on the ground is that the Senator Arianwen is a frontrunner for the election, much to House Eisensturm's dismay. Vilde is taken aback by this, and wonders why her mother would choose her political campaign as opposed to coming after her daughter.

"Lyara Porter wishes to head to Mezro to settle her new capital," Benedict chuckles as he says this. "*Promise*. A load of bullshit, if you ask me. I'm not really feeling the jungle, I'm more of a city man myself, but we'll see," he says, finishing his drink. Rising from his seat, Salazar tries to dap him up, only to be met with disdain from the haughty noble. Benedict bids Raphael and Vilde adieu as he and his attendant heads off.

Notions of Promotion

As Wang Lei and Breakbones stand at attention, Lyara Porter takes over Breakbones's office and room. Her assistant, the halfling Jack, scampers into the half-orc commander's room and begins unpacking for the Castellan.

Breakbones presents a report to Lyara Porter, explaining that Wang Lei informed her of a possible assault last night. As the Camp readied, she entrusted the defense of the western wall to Wang Lei, who then went missing.

Wang Lei takes the opportunity to explain himself, telling the both of them about the False Hydra under the camp. He goes a step further, pointing out that they are free to head down the burrows behind the latrine to find evidence of this monster.

As Breakbones begins to argue, Lyara Porter cuts her off. "Enough," the Castellan commands. "Breakbones, and I am trying to think of an easy way to tell you this, but I mean, really you have to be the most useless person I have ever met. Why didn't you have any scouts or rangers outside on patrol to warn you of an incoming attack?"

Breakbones goes to speak, but decides to stay quiet.

"Forgetting the siege for a minute," Lyara continues. "You have been living blissfully unaware of a powerful monster, right in your own camp, feeding off your men one by one. The only reason you are still alive is because Wang Lei over here showed up and saved your sorry ass."

Lyara Porter looks up at Wang Lei for a minute, considering him.

“Get out,” she says. “Repair the camp’s defenses, I want this place operational and fortified again by tonight. If I see anyone, and I mean *anyone* taking a break, give them forty lashes.” Breakbones hurries out of the room and heads back to preparation.

With only Wang Lei in the room, Lyara Porter sighs. “I’m sorry you had to see that,” she says. “Don’t want to blame the help, but when your Lieutenant’s a tusker, you’re going to have to do the heavy lifting around here. How are things in Summer’s Outpost?”

Wang Lei shares that things were okay when they left, but he has had a vision of trouble brewing and would like to finish his quest here as quickly as possible to go back to Castellan Eddard.

“You know, I’m not stupid,” Lyara continues. “The moment I saw your name on the Expedition, I knew what ole Ned was tryna do. He wants you to take over him, right?”

Wang Lei nods.

“I do think I would regret it if I did not at least try,” Lyara sighs. “I know you’re loyal to Eddard, but look. When you complete the expedition and head back to the mainland, you would at best be Castellan of Summer’s Outpost. I think you’re a man of talent. Tell me, who slew the Hydra?”

Wang Lei shares that while he dealt the finishing blow, it was a joint effort.

“Of course,” Lyara says. “Talent cannot be nurtured, only sought out. I myself am in the process of a promotion myself, and would be in need of a replacement. The thing is, aside from being the Castellan of Fort Sempter, you would be the General of the Kroonstad Expeditionary Forces.”

Wang Lei recognizes that those are made-up titles, and do not mean anything. He asks about her upcoming promotion.

Lyara Porter explains that she is founding her own kingdom right here in Kroonstad, colonizing the lands. “We will, of course, remain subservient to the Empire, but here I’d have my own nation and be a queen.” A devilish smile crosses her face. “Crazy, I know, but this is legitimized by the Chamber of Lords-Advisory. You see the two people I came with? They are with House Luxjaro.”

Focused on the problem, Wang Lei tries to bring the Castellan back to the earth. “There is a hag out there,” he points out. “Organizing an attack on the Camp. Is stopping her of interest to you?”

“No, not really,” Lyara Porter shrugs. “Zarula is not in the borders of the New African Republic.”



She sees that the paladin's thoughts are elsewhere, and pulls back. "Look, if you need more time to think on the offer, please. I'm not new to the art of negotiation. After all, I'm a queen," she chuckles. "Take your time. Jack! Come get this armour off me."

The halfling rushes out, and begins undoing her straps.

Wang Lei takes in the Castellan, trying to see if there's a magical artifact of some kind urging her to act in this unhinged manner. He sees the halfling put up a dark greatsword. The obsidian blade shines like a piece of night sky filled with stars.

Wang Lei asks about the sword, prompting a laugh from the Castellan. "Would that sweeten the deal for you, sugar?" She asks. "Unfortunately, I pulled this out of a stone. It is the symbol of my reign, and I cannot give it to you."

Wang Lei nods at this, deciding to head off. As he does so, the Castellan stops him for a final question. "Tell me, sugar. Where did your elven friend get the choker from?"

"I don't know," Wang Lei says. "Why?"

"Former assailants of mine had a similar choker," the Castellan explained. "It seems to be drawing her blood from her body for some kind of sorcery. No matter, I will speak to her about it."

Wang Lei nods and leaves the room. He seeks out Lieutenant Niles Breakbones, who is overseeing the repair of the western wall.

"Hey, you've got a minute?"

The half-orc barks some orders at the soldiers as she steps aside, glaring at Wang Lei.

"Do you think the Castellan's acting... a bit strange?"

"No," Breakbones replies flatly. "She's always been a bitch."

"And what about all that stuff about becoming queen?"

"That's new," Breakbones replies. "I don't know anything about that."

"Hypothetically," Wang Lei says. "If we were to stage a coup, would you be down?"

Breakbones' eyes widened in surprise, shocked at the suggestion of treason. "And what happens after that?" she asks. "Let's say we kill her. What next? Who takes over? You? She is the commander of the Revolutionary Guard and the symbol of the Empire in these lands."

Wang Lei shares his concerns that she is mentally unstable and that she should not take over the continent, pointing out that she has been brutalizing the locals.

Breakbones shares that while the Castellan is a bad person and a negative influence, her authority keeps the soldiers in line. The further they are from home, the longer they stay, the more lawless they become, and the Castellan is keeping them in check by allowing such corruption from time to time.

Wang Lei explains that if she ascends to a position of power, she will be a dangerous threat and must be dealt with now.

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a successful **DC 15** check, Breakbones decides to trust Wang Lei. On a successful **DC 20** check, he wins her over to stage a coup.

Convinced by the paladin, Breakbones asks "what's the plan?" Wang Lei replies that they will need some time to reconvene, and just asks her to marshal those who are willing. Breakbones nods, and says she'll get on it.

Locket of the Stolen Heart



Heading back to her tent to rest, Vilde sees Mason sitting by her bed. As she approaches he looks up, with a smile.

"M'lady," He says, bowing. "I've been waiting for you."

Vilde smiles and says, "Oh, what for?"

The soldier produces a small, gold heart-shaped locket. "I found this downstairs, back by the acid lake." He produces the *Lockets of the Stolen Heart*.

"These are magical," he explains. "They have to be attuned by two separate people." Mason opens the locket, showing a portrait of Cregan, the dead goliath. He attunes to the Locket, and the image in the pendant shifts to Vilde's visage. "It would help us in battle."

"U-uh," Vilde says. "Um, I'm kind of attuned to a few other items right now."

Mason is stunned. He takes a step back, just long enough for Vilde to see that she's hurt him.

"I - I mean," Vilde says. "I'll still wear it, I just kind of can't - "

"It's alright, m'lady," the squire takes a step back and bows, his voice shaking. "I understand. Excuse me, I think I'm needed at the western wall." He leaves the room, rushing away.

Vilde curses at herself, snatching the Locket and heading straight to Raphael's tent.

"Broooo," she says. "You won't believe what just happened. I need your help."

Rousing the sorcerer, he raises an eyebrow at the rogue. "What's up?"

Vilde launches into a tirade. "Mason and I have a 'will they won't they' thing going, and then he had to go and offer me a locket, and I want to wear it but I can't because I am really out of attunement slots and I can't give up the *Stone of Good Luck* from my mother - "

"Okay, okay," the sorcerer asks, desperate for some sleep. "What do you want?"

Vilde asks Raphael to help change the Locket's image, such that it has his face in it to give the impression that she has attuned to the *Locket of the Stolen Heart.*

Intelligence (Arcana) Check

On a successful **DC 15** check, Raphael succeeds and changes the image of the locket.

"There," he says. "Now can I go back to sleep?"

Quarrel with the Queen

The Party retires, exhausted from their exploits in the previous day. As Vilde completes her trance, she feels sound suck out from the air all around her. With blood pounding in her ears, she opens her eyes to the sight of a pillow coming down to suffocate her.

The pillow covers her face as the assailant straddles her, putting their full weight down. Vilde struggles to breathe as she is surprised by the attacker.

"MASON," she thinks. "I DON'T LIKE BDSM!"

Quarrel with the Queen

Initiative	Monster	Quantity	AC	HP	Remarks
19	Knight	4	18	52	-

Eldritch Knight

Small or Medium Humanoid, Neutral

Armor Class 18
Hit Points 58 (8d8 + 16)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	11 (+0)	15 (+2)

Immunities Frightened
Senses Passive Perception 10
Languages Common, Elvish
Initiative Bonus +0

Actions

Multiattack. The knight makes two attacks, using *Greatsword* or *Heavy Crossbow* in any combination.

Greatsword. *Melee Attack Roll*: +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit*: 10 (2d6 + 3) Slashing damage plus 4 (1d8) Radiant damage.

Heavy Crossbow. *Ranged Attack Roll*: +2, range 100/400 ft. *Hit*: 11 (2d10) Piercing damage plus 4 (1d8) Radiant damage.

Spellcasting. The eldritch knight casts one of the following spells, using Intelligence as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 12):

- At will: *booming blade, gust*
- 1/day: *chromatic orb, thunderwave*

Reactions

Parry. *Trigger*: The knight is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. *Response*: The knight adds 2 to its AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Shield (1/Day). Trigger: The knight is hit by a attack roll. Response: The knight adds 5 to its AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Bucking her hips, she flings the unseen attacker off her. Leaping into action, she is surrounded by four knights. They swing on her, slashing her violently. As she loses blood, the four knights knock her unconscious before she can act.

Bravewing

The Party comes to, gathering for lunch in the mess hall. Before Wang Lei leaves the Commanders' Tent with Hazel, he walks over to the Castellan's office. He notices that there are two knights stationed outside, and hears moaning from within.

Arriving in the mess hall, the Party notices Vilde's absence; Salazar decides to go get her before the Party discusses their next steps. As he does so, Wang Lei and Raphael takes the time to update the rest of the group. Raphael warns Hazel about Benedict Luxjaro's hunt for Saleander's followers, and tells her to keep her religious iconography hidden for now.

Wang Lei also informs the group about a potential coup, as they might seek to stop the tyrannical Castellan.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
On a successful **DC 15** check, Salazar finds Bravewing's Journal in Vilde's belongings.

Entering Mason's tent, Salazar sees blood splatters all around the tent. Peeking out of her backpack is a small, leather journal. Opening it up, fearing it is a suicide note of some kind, the wizard begins to thumb through the pages.

Distracted by the journal, Salazar does not return to the mess hall, prompting the rest to finish their meal and head over. As they enter, they see Salazar still reading the journal.

Hazel asks what the wizard is doing, but Raphael quickly realizes that the journal belonged to the former captain of the Star Goddess. Snatching it out of the wizard's hands, the sorcerer obsessively reads the book. He learns that, in House Antarra's search for the Key, his father chartered an expedition, sailing past various landmarks in Kroonstad like the River Tiryki and Kirsabal's Rest before reaching Nagalore, the Garden of Lost Dreams. There, the expedition reaches a horrific climax at the ruined ziggurat as Lord Antarra communed with a powerful interdimensional entity. The cultist noble then commandeered the vessel, barricaded the engine room, and deliberately burned through their remaining fuel while circling a landmark known as *the Heart of Ubtao*. The journal concludes on Day 12 with Bravewing, Sylvio, and Falx preparing a desperate, final mutiny to retake the engine room and attempt a crash-landing in the Aldani Basin to escape with their lives. Ayo watches the sorcerer read hungrily from the book, wary of a potential psychotic break.

Concerned about their missing friend, Thaisha and Hazel began discussing how to deal with the situation. Salazar postulates that she might have been murdered, prompting Thaisha to suggest then that it might be best if they all leave quickly. Hazel insists in trying to find her, casting *Speak with Plants*. She sees the shimmering image of four knights carrying an unconscious Vilde towards the latrine, prompting her to realize they must have taken the rogue back to the Hydra's lair.



Wang Lei suggests to the gang to split up; half of them can prepare for the coup, while the others can find and free Vilde. Wang Lei, Salazar, Wukong, Yandala and Thaisha will scout and prepare for a battle against the Castellan and those loyal to her, while Raphael, Hazel and Gaya goes to find Vilde.

Freeing Vilde

In the Hydra's lair, Vilde comes to. The two guards have disarmed her, and tied her to a chair by the edge of the acid lake.

"Where did you get the choker from?" One of the guards demanded. Vilde insults the guards and spits at one of them. Wordlessly, they seize her, submerging her face into the lake. The burning liquid stings Vilde with a hungry hiss, prompting her screams. She feigns unconsciousness as the guards pull her back out.

Charisma (Performance) Check
On a successful **DC 15** check, the knights believe Vilde is unconscious from the acid.

In the split second before she shuts her eyes to feign incapacitation, Vilde sees Ayo skulking behind the guards. The knights leave the rogue slumped in the chair as they wait for her to wake up once again.

As they do so, they see a tiny, shimmering rabbit clamber up to them. The rabbit waves a cheeky hello as dozens of other glowing rabbits explode out from it, searing the guards.

Seizing the opportunity, Vilde tries to undo her shackles, which remain stubbornly fastened. She casts *Druidcraft,* mimicking the False Hydra's song in the hopes of convincing the knights that the False Hydra is back.

While one of the guards believes it, the other knight slaps the naive guy and points to Vilde. Still surprised by the *Spirit Guardians,* the knights do not see Raphael coming. Thick, purple tentacles erupt from the black granite, restraining the arms of the two knights and bringing them to their knees.

Ayo, Gaya and Hazel rush up, helping to undo Vilde's manacles. She dons her armour and equipment again, glaring down at the captives.

"I don't need both of you," Vilde roars. "What does that bitch want with me?"